

Paper 2 Sections B & C Practice Set — Answer Key

Model answers with full annotated reasoning for all 51 questions

This Answer Key shows you not just what the correct answer is, but **how to arrive at it** using the techniques from the Working Notes.

For every question you will see four annotation lines followed by the model answer and a brief marker commentary:

- **SWIFT signal** — which (if any) of the words *Suggest* / *Why* / *Impression* / *Feeling* / *Tone* appears in the question. This determines the category.
- **Category** → **Type** → **Sequence** — which category (A or B), which of the 16 question types (A1–A8 or B1–B8), and whether FLIP or EIL is the move-sequence.
- **Template applied** — the sentence template from the Working Notes that fits this question type, with the slots filled in.
- **Reasoning** — the short logical chain that produces the answer from the text.

This annotation is the **point of the document**. Do not skip to the model answer alone — the reasoning is what you are training.

Passage 1 — “The Last Crossing” (Q1–Q16)

Q1 — Type B1 (Basic Inference) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Why do you think’ → **W** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → **Type** → **Sequence:** Cat B → B1 Basic Inference → EIL.

Template applied: “The detail of ‘the silence that followed felt strange’ suggests that Ravi felt unsettled and disoriented, which shows that he stopped walking because he was caught off guard by the sudden darkness.”

Reasoning: The action (stopping) is not random — it is a response to fear and confusion at the sudden loss of light. Anchor the inference (unsettled, disoriented) to the supporting detail (“silence felt strange” / “the night holding its breath”).

Model answer: Ravi stops walking because he is startled and unsettled by the sudden darkness and the eerie silence that follows — a moment for which he had not prepared. *Supporting detail:* the writer says the silence felt strange, “as though the night itself had been holding its breath”. **Marker commentary:** One mark for the inference (startled / unsettled / fearful), one mark for a relevant supporting detail.

Q2 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Simile) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → **S** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → **Type** → **Sequence:** Cat B → B5 Literary Device → EIL via comparison transfer.

Template applied: “The simile compares the streetlamps to obedient soldiers, which suggests that the streetlamps were orderly, uniform and dependable.”

Reasoning: Obedient soldiers stand in straight, regular lines and follow command without fail. Transfer those qualities to the streetlamps: orderly, regularly spaced, reliable.

Model answer: The simile suggests that the streetlamps were orderly and regularly spaced, standing in disciplined rows along the road, and that their reliable presence gave the street a sense of order and security.

Marker commentary: The mark is for transferring at least one quality of soldiers (order, regularity, discipline, reliability) to the streetlamps.

Q3 — Type A2 (Targeted Quotation) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word → Cat A. Question demands ‘one word’ → A2.
Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A2 Targeted Quotation Extraction → FLIP, stopping at L.
Template applied: “*feeble*.”
Reasoning: Scan Paragraph 2 for words conveying low power. “Feeble” (modifying the red battery icon) is precise. Inverted commas required.

Model answer: “feeble”. **Marker commentary:** “Dead” is also acceptable (“something already dead”). “Red” alone is not — it describes colour, not low power.

Q4 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Personification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.
Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B5 Literary Device → EIL via personification.
Template applied: “The personification compares the phone to something already dead, which suggests that the phone has lost all responsiveness and that Ravi has lost his only means of contacting help.”
Reasoning: The phone is given the human quality of indifference; “something already dead” transfers finality and unresponsiveness. Two implications: (a) the phone is beyond saving, (b) Ravi is now cut off.

Model answer: The personification suggests that the phone is utterly unresponsive — as if it has already lost all life — and is therefore beyond rescue. It also reinforces Ravi’s growing isolation, as the device he depended on has effectively abandoned him. **Marker commentary:** Two distinct points needed: (i) the phone’s total unresponsiveness; (ii) Ravi’s isolation. Do not award both marks for restating the same idea.

Q5 — Type B6 (Language-Use / Stylistic Effect) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘How the language’ → classic Cat B style question.
Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B6 Language-Use → quote → “suggests” → explanation, repeat.
Template applied: “The phrase ‘a black mouth opening into nothing’ suggests that the bus stop appeared monstrous and devouring, reinforcing the impression of menace. In addition, the bus shelter ‘was no longer a shelter’ conveys the loss of its protective function, which further makes it threatening.”
Reasoning: Two distinct details, two distinct explanations. The metaphor (“black mouth”) makes the shelter monstrous; the inversion (“no longer a shelter”) strips it of safety. Do not repeat the same explanation.

Model answer:

1. The metaphor “a black mouth opening into nothing” suggests that the bus stop has become predatory — like a creature with an open jaw waiting to swallow whoever enters. The image is hostile and devouring.
2. The phrase “no longer a shelter” conveys the loss of the bus stop’s protective function. What should have been a place of refuge has been emptied of that purpose, making it feel exposed and unsafe.

Marker commentary: One mark per quote + explanation pair, provided the explanation actually addresses the “threatening” descriptor in the question.

Q6 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Simile) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.
Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B5 → EIL via comparison transfer.
Template applied: “The simile compares the headlights to searchlights in a prison yard, which suggests that Ravi feels exposed and surveilled, as if he were a fugitive being hunted.”
Reasoning: Searchlights in a prison yard imply pursuit, exposure and criminality. Transfer to Ravi: he feels watched, vulnerable, and treated as if he were doing something wrong.

Model answer: The simile suggests that Ravi feels exposed and watched, as though he were a prisoner under surveillance — vulnerable, conspicuous, and unable to hide. **Marker commentary:** The mark requires the transfer to a feeling of exposure or surveillance.

Q7 — Type A1 (Direct Detail) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; ‘give one detail’ is the literal-retrieval signal.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A1 → FLIP, lifting cleanly.

Template applied: “The detail is that the old man was ‘peering at him’ from beneath the awning.”

Reasoning: Scan Paragraph 4 for evidence of prior observation. “peering at him” demonstrates that the man had been watching before speaking.

Model answer: The old man was already “peering at him from beneath the awning of a shuttered shop” before he spoke, showing he had been observing Ravi for some time. **Marker commentary:** Lift is acceptable; the marker wants the specific detail.

Q8 — Type B4 (State-of-Mind / Reaction) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT trigger word but ‘state of mind’ is the B4 signal. Also ‘in your own words’ → paraphrase demanded.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B4 State-of-Mind → EIL + own-words substitution.

Template applied: “Ravi is daunted and intimidated — so apprehensive that the journey feels as forbidding to him as travelling through a country whose dangers he cannot anticipate.”

Reasoning: The simile (“hostile country”) is the evidence. Translate the physical comparison (hostile country) into the corresponding mental state (apprehension, dread, intimidation). Use synonyms; do not lift the word “hostile”.

Model answer: Ravi feels apprehensive and daunted: the walk home, which would ordinarily seem short, now appears menacing and unfamiliar, as though every step might bring him into contact with unseen dangers. **Marker commentary:** (i) precise emotion (apprehension / dread / intimidation); (ii) explanation showing why the simile fits his mental state. Lifting “hostile” loses the own-words mark.

Q9 — Type B3 (Tone / Attitude) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Tone’ → T in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B3 Tone → short, precise tone-word.

Template applied: “The old man’s tone is wise and admonitory (or cautionary / sage).”

Reasoning: The old man warns Ravi gently — not harshly, not mockingly. He is offering counsel based on experience. “Admonitory” or “cautionary” captures both the warning and the kindness.

Model answer: The tone is cautionary (or admonitory / sagely). The old man is gently warning Ravi to be alert, while drawing on the wisdom of experience. **Marker commentary:** “Wise” / “avuncular” / “cautionary” all score. “Mean” or “angry” would not.

Q10 — Type B7 (Word-Choice / Vocabulary) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggests’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B7 Word-Choice Inference → EIL via implication of word.

Template applied: “It suggests that Ravi feels exposed and pursued, implying that even ordinary sounds become evidence of his presence to a hostile watcher.”

Reasoning: The personification of the road (“reporting his progress”) turns a neutral surface into an informer. The implication: Ravi feels paranoid and watched.

Model answer: The phrase suggests that Ravi feels paranoid and exposed: even the ordinary sound of his footsteps seems amplified into a signal that betrays his presence to whoever might be hunting him in the dark. **Marker commentary:** The mark is for capturing the feeling of vulnerability or paranoia.

Q11 — Type A6 (Contrast Identification) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; ‘identify the contrast’ is the explicit A6 signal.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A6 Contrast → FLIP; state both sides.

Template applied: “Whereas a wall is solid and impassable, a curtain is soft and can be pushed through.”

Reasoning: The two halves: wall = impenetrable barrier; curtain = penetrable obstacle. The contrast is between absolute obstruction and yielding resistance.

Model answer: The contrast is between something impenetrable (a wall, which cannot be crossed) and something yielding (a curtain, which is dense but can be moved through). The writer is showing that Ravi’s perception of the dark has shifted from an absolute obstacle to a passable one. **Marker commentary:** Both halves of the contrast must appear.

Q12 — Type A4 (Multi-Evidence Justification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “two pieces of evidence” is the A4 signal.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A4 Multi-Evidence → FLIP; two distinct evidence + link pairs.

Template applied: “Firstly, the writer says his mother used to walk the corridor with him every night, which shows that they were once physically close. Secondly, the writer says, ‘He had not held her hand in years’, which shows that this closeness has since faded.”

Reasoning: Two distinct pieces. The first establishes past closeness; the second establishes its decline. Do not give two versions of the same point.

Model answer:

1. In childhood, Ravi’s mother walked the corridor with him every night, holding his hand — evidence of regular physical comfort and reassurance.
2. The writer explicitly says, “He had not held her hand in years” — evidence that this physical closeness has been absent for a long time.

Marker commentary: Each evidence must be from Paragraph 9. Two restatements of the same point score only one mark.

Q13 — Type B1 (Basic Inference) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B1 Basic Inference → EIL.

Template applied: “The action of not speaking and pulling him into a ‘fierce’ embrace suggests that her feelings were overwhelming — relief and love so strong that words would have been inadequate.”

Reasoning: Silence + a fierce embrace = an emotion too large for speech. The inference is (a) overwhelming relief, (b) deep love.

Model answer: Her behaviour suggests that her feelings were overwhelming — she was so flooded with relief at his safe return, and so afraid of what might have happened to him, that words would have been inadequate. The “fierce embrace” conveys both love and the intensity of her earlier fear. **Marker commentary:** Two distinct points (relief and love / fear). One mark each.

Q14 — Type B2 (Character Trait / Impression) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word but ‘tell us about’ / final image → closest signal is ‘impression’, a B2 trigger.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B2 Character Impression → precise trait + anchor.

Template applied: “The mother comes across as deeply protective and emotionally invested — her holding him as if she had been the one walking through the dark shows that she had been suffering vicariously throughout his absence.”

Reasoning: The reversal (*she* held *him* as if she had been walking through the dark) implies that her experience of waiting was as fraught as his journey. The trait: deeply empathetic, protective, anxious.

Model answer: The mother comes across as deeply empathetic and protective. The reversal — that *she* clings to him as if she had been the one walking through the dark — shows that her experience of waiting was as fraught and frightening as his actual journey. **Marker commentary:** “Empathetic” / “protective” / “deeply anxious” all score; “worried” alone is too generic.

Q15 — Type A7 (Flow-Chart Role Mapping) — [4]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; flow-chart task with phrase bank → A7.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A7 Flow-Chart → FLIP, then match.

Template applied: (No template prose; just write the matched phrase verbatim.)

Reasoning: For each paragraph range, find the dominant emotional state; pick the phrase whose meaning matches most precisely; eliminate distractors.

Model answer:

- Paragraphs 1–3: **feeling suddenly exposed and isolated** (Ravi is alone with a dead phone, in the dark, watched by passing headlights).
- Paragraphs 4–6: **resolving to act despite fear** (he chooses to walk home rather than wait).
- Paragraphs 7–8: **gradually overcoming his fear** (his eyes adjust; the dark becomes “less a wall than a curtain”).
- Paragraphs 9–10: **reflecting on the unspoken bond with a parent** (he thinks of his mother’s earlier care and is reunited with her in silence).

Marker commentary: One mark per correct match. “Refusing to confront a danger” is a distractor (he confronts it). “Realising he is no longer needed at home” is a distractor (the opposite is true).

Q16 — Type B2 (Character Trait / Impression) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Impression’ → I in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B2 → precise trait + anchor; two marks → two traits or one trait + extended anchor.

Template applied: “Ravi comes across as initially fearful but ultimately resilient — his hesitation at the bus stop shows his fear, while his decision to walk home and his calm reflection on his mother show his developing courage and self-awareness.”

Reasoning: Two-mark version: name two complementary traits, anchor each.

Model answer: Ravi comes across as initially fearful but ultimately resilient and reflective. His paralysis at the dark bus stop and his startled reaction to the blackout show his fear; his decision to walk home alone and his quiet reflection on his mother’s earlier care show his growing courage and emotional maturity. **Marker commentary:** Two distinct traits, each anchored to a different part of the passage.

Passage 2 — “The Last Stall” (Q17–Q29)

Q17 — Type A1 (Direct Detail) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “identify one detail” → A1.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A1 → FLIP, lift.

Template applied: “The detail is that she has been frying carrot cake at the same stall for forty-three years.”

Reasoning: Any one of: forty-three-year tenure; arms moving with “the certainty of habit”; not needing to look at her hands. All score.

Model answer: Madam Lim has been frying carrot cake at the same stall for forty-three years. **Marker commentary:** “She did not look at her hands as she worked” is also acceptable.

Q18 — Type A3 (Own-Words Paraphrase) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “in your own words” is the A3 signal.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A3 → FLIP, finishing at P (paraphrase).

Template applied: “The writer means that Madam Lim works with the confidence and automatic precision of someone whose hands have repeated the task so many times that conscious thought is no longer required.”

Reasoning: Substitute: “certainty” → “confidence / assurance”; “habit” → “routine / repeated practice”. Do not reuse the original words.

Model answer: The phrase means that her hands move with the assurance of long repetition — her actions are so deeply ingrained through years of practice that she performs them automatically, without needing to think or look. **Marker commentary:** Lifting “certainty” or “habit” costs the own-words mark.

Q19 — Type B1 (Basic Inference) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B1 → EIL.

Template applied: “The action of folding the letter carefully and returning to the wok suggests that Madam Lim is stoic and unwilling to dramatise her distress, which shows that she suppresses her emotions and prioritises her work.”

Reasoning: Two distinct inferences available: (a) emotional restraint / stoicism; (b) prioritising duty over personal feeling. Both score.

Model answer: Her reaction suggests that she is stoic and emotionally restrained: rather than reacting visibly to the bad news, she immediately returns to her work. This also implies that her sense of duty to her customers takes priority over her own feelings. **Marker commentary:** Two marks: (i) emotional restraint; (ii) prioritising duty / customers.

Q20 — Type B6 (Language-Use / Stylistic Effect) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘What is the effect’ → B6 signal (effect of a stylistic choice).

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B6 → name the device + explain its effect.

Template applied: “The repetition ‘there were customers to serve’ suggests that customer service is the unchanging fact of her life, reinforcing the impression of her unbroken devotion to her work. In addition, the slight variation (‘still’ → ‘always’) conveys that this devotion is timeless, extending beyond the immediate moment.”

Reasoning: Repetition is the device; the effect is to emphasise the constancy / centrality of her work. The shift from “still” to “always” deepens the point.

Model answer: The repetition emphasises that serving customers is the constant, unchanging fact of Madam Lim’s life — a routine that overrides personal upset. The slight shift from “still” to “always” broadens the meaning, suggesting that this devotion is not just present but timeless, extending across her entire forty-three-year tenure. **Marker commentary:** (i) identification of repetition as the device + its emphatic effect; (ii) the shift from “still” to “always”.

Q21 — Type B1 (Basic Inference) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B1 → EIL.

Template applied: “The action of tipping double the meal price suggests that Mr Goh feels deep affection and regret, and that he wants to express gratitude that cannot be put into words.”

Reasoning: The over-tip is a non-verbal farewell — gratitude, affection, and unspoken sorrow at the impending closure.

Model answer: The over-tip suggests that Mr Goh feels deep affection and regret, and that he is using money as a way of expressing gratitude that he cannot articulate in words. **Marker commentary:** “Sad” / “thankful” both score.

Q22 — Type A1 (Direct Detail) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “give one piece of evidence” → A1.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A1 → FLIP, lift.

Template applied: “The detail is the ‘quick, tired smile’ she gave Mr Goh while telling him not to think about it.”

Reasoning: The “quick, tired smile” + the instruction to “not think about it” both show her concealment.

Model answer: Madam Lim gave Mr Goh a “quick, tired smile” and told him not to think about the closure — showing that she was concealing her own feelings to spare him. **Marker commentary:** Either the smile detail or the “don’t think about it” instruction is acceptable.

Q23 — Type A3 (Own-Words Paraphrase) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “in your own words” → A3.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A3 → FLIP, finishing at P.

Template applied: “Madam Lim does not want to retire because the stall is not merely her job — it provides the structure and meaning of her daily life, and without it her days would be empty and purposeless.”

Reasoning: Two ideas to capture: (a) the stall is not work but identity / structure; (b) without it, her days would have no shape.

Model answer: For Madam Lim, the stall is not simply employment but the framework that organises her entire daily life. The routine of preparing the wok, slicing the radish, and serving regulars gives her days purpose. Without the stall, she fears her time would be formless and empty. **Marker commentary:** (i) stall = structure / identity, not just income; (ii) without it, life would lose shape.

Q24 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Metaphor) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B5 → EIL via comparison transfer.

Template applied: “The metaphor compares the day to a container into which life is poured, which suggests that Madam Lim regards the stall as the vessel that gives her time its meaningful shape; without it, her days would have no form to hold them.”

Reasoning: The day is implicitly a container; the stall is what is poured into it. Without the container, the contents have no shape. The image conveys formlessness and emptiness without the stall.

Model answer: The metaphor suggests that Madam Lim sees the stall as the vessel that contains and shapes her time. Without it, her hours would be like liquid without a container — formless, directionless, and ultimately wasted. The image powerfully conveys her sense that the stall does not just occupy her days but gives them meaning. **Marker commentary:** Two marks: (i) recognition that the stall = vessel / container; (ii) implication that without it her life would be formless.

Q25 — Type A1 (Direct Detail) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; identify two literal details → A1.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A1 → FLIP, lift.

Template applied: “The prawn-noodle man and the laksa lady (and the cze char couple).”

Reasoning: Lift any two of the three other stalls named in Paragraph 5.

Model answer: Any two of: the prawn-noodle man, the laksa lady, the young couple at the cze char unit. **Marker commentary:** Excess Denied applies — giving four names where two were asked for is acceptable only if all four are correct.

Q26 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Simile) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B5 → EIL via comparison transfer.

Template applied: “The simile compares her sadness to sediment in a glass of kopi-o left too long, which suggests that her sadness is slow, settling, accumulating gradually over time rather than appearing as a sudden burst of grief.”

Reasoning: Sediment forms slowly, settles at the bottom, and is invisible until the liquid is still. Transfer to her sadness: slow-forming, deeply settled, quietly persistent.

Model answer: The simile suggests that Madam Lim’s sadness is quiet, slow-forming, and gradually settling — not a sudden burst of grief but something that has accumulated over time and now rests heavily and immovably at the base of her being. **Marker commentary:** (i) slow / gradual accumulation; (ii) deep / settled / persistent. Both qualities required for two marks.

Q27 — Type B3 (Tone / Attitude) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Tone’ → **T** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B3 → precise tone-word.

Template applied: “The writer’s tone is sympathetic and elegiac (or wistful / mournful).”

Reasoning: The writer describes her loss without judgement, with measured compassion and a sense of mourning for what is passing.

Model answer: The writer’s tone is sympathetic and elegiac — mournful for what is being lost, but quiet and dignified rather than angry or sentimental. **Marker commentary:** “Wistful” / “compassionate” / “mournful” all score. “Sad” alone is too vague.

Q28 — Type B2 (Character Trait / Impression) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Impression’ → **I** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B2 → precise traits + anchors.

Template applied: “Madam Lim comes across as stoic and devoted — her continued work after the closure letter shows her resilience, and her insistence that the stall is more than mere employment shows her deep emotional investment.”

Reasoning: Two traits, anchored to different parts of the passage.

Model answer: Madam Lim comes across as stoic and deeply devoted. Her refusal to dramatise her distress after the closure letter shows her resilience and emotional restraint; her conviction that the stall is the shape of her days, not just her work, shows the depth of her attachment to her vocation. **Marker commentary:** Two distinct traits, each anchored.

Q29 — Type A2 (Targeted Quotation) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “identify the phrase, not more than five words” → A2.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A2 → FLIP, stopping at L.

Template applied: “*‘a slow, settling sadness’*”

Reasoning: Exactly five words; captures the precise nature of her loss; in inverted commas.

Model answer: “a slow, settling sadness”. **Marker commentary:** Must be in inverted commas and exactly five words or fewer. “A slow, settling sadness, like the sediment” is too long.

Passage 3 — “The Quiet Death of Reading” (Q30–Q44)

Q30 — Type A8 (Reason / Justification) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; ‘why’ as cause (the reason is in the text) → A8.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A8 → FLIP, find cause + rephrase.

Template applied: “This is because the average Singaporean reads only two books a year for leisure, which means that the act of reading has become so rare that the country has effectively lost the habit.”

Reasoning: Locate the supporting figure; rephrase the consequence (forgotten).

Model answer: The writer’s reason is that the average Singaporean adult now reads only two books per year for leisure — a figure that has halved over the past decade — which suggests that the country has lost the habit of reading altogether. **Marker commentary:** Must capture the statistic or the halving trend.

Q31 — Type B7 (Word-Choice / Vocabulary) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → **S** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B7 → EIL via implication of word.

Template applied: “It suggests that the smartphone has invaded and taken over the spaces where reading used to occur, implying both an aggressive expansion and the displacement of an earlier inhabitant.”

Reasoning: “Colonised” carries historical connotations of forceful occupation and the displacement of a prior population. The smartphone has not merely entered these spaces — it has taken them by force.

Model answer: The word “colonised” suggests that the smartphone has aggressively invaded and taken over spaces that once belonged to reading, displacing it rather than merely sharing the territory. It implies a hostile, total occupation. **Marker commentary:** (i) aggressive / forceful takeover; (ii) displacement of the previous activity.

Q32 — Type A8 (Reason / Justification) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “why” as cause → A8.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A8 → FLIP.

Template applied: “This is because the smartphone is more convenient and varied than a book, which means people instinctively reach for it whenever they have a free moment.”

Reasoning: Lift the reason: the phone offers more variety, convenience and responsiveness; therefore it wins the contest for attention.

Model answer: The smartphone has displaced reading because it is more convenient, more responsive, and infinitely more varied than a paperback — making it the natural default for any spare moment. **Marker commentary:** Any one of: convenience, responsiveness, variety.

Q33 — Type A3 (Own-Words Paraphrase) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “in your own words” → A3.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A3 → FLIP, finishing at P.

Template applied: “Schools are blamed firstly because they present reading as a duty rather than a pleasure, and secondly because they over-analyse books to the point that students lose any enjoyment of them.”

Reasoning: Two reasons: (i) reading framed as a chore; (ii) excessive analytical dissection drains the pleasure.

Model answer: The writer blames schools because (i) they present reading as an obligation tied to assessment rather than as something enjoyable, and (ii) they over-analyse texts — dissecting them for themes and devices — until students lose any sense of pleasure in the reading itself. **Marker commentary:** (i) duty / obligation framing; (ii) over-analysis draining pleasure. Lifting “chore” or “dissected” loses the own-words mark.

Q34 — Type B8 (Inverted-Comma / Punctuation) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Why’ as rhetorical-purpose question → **W** in SWIFT → Cat B (specifically B8 because of inverted commas).

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B8 → name purpose + explain real view.

Template applied: “The inverted commas suggest that the writer is being sceptical or dismissive: although the words ‘themes’ and ‘devices’ are taken seriously by the educational system, the writer actually thinks that they are reductive labels that strip books of their original meaning.”

Reasoning: Inverted commas distance the writer from the words. The writer is mocking the analytical jargon, signalling that this technical apparatus is part of the problem.

Model answer: The inverted commas suggest that the writer is being sceptical or dismissive of these educational categories. Although “themes” and “devices” are treated as serious analytical tools by schools, the writer regards them as reductive labels that strip books of their pleasure and meaning. **Marker commentary:** (i) rhetorical distance / scepticism; (ii) what the writer actually thinks (that the categories are part of the damage).

Q35 — Type A4 (Multi-Evidence Justification) — [3]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “three pieces of evidence” → A4.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A4 → FLIP; three distinct evidence + link pairs.

Template applied: “Firstly, reading cultivates ‘a long, slow, deepening attention’ that no other activity replicates, which shows the loss of a key cognitive skill. Secondly, reading is the ‘foundation of empathy’, meaning its decline reduces our ability to understand others. Thirdly, the writer claims that a society that does not read will become one that does not think, showing the long-term civic cost.”

Reasoning: Three distinct costs: attention, empathy, civic / intellectual life.

Model answer:

1. Reading cultivates a long, slow, deepening attention that no other activity replicates — the loss of which damages cognitive depth.
2. Reading is described as the foundation of empathy, judgement, and independent thought — its decline therefore weakens these qualities in society.
3. The writer concludes that a society that does not read will, in time, become a society that does not think — showing that the cost extends to the intellectual character of the nation.

Marker commentary: Three distinct pieces required; restating the same point in different words scores only one mark.

Q36 — Type B3 (Tone / Attitude) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Tone’ → T in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B3 → precise tone-word.

Template applied: “The writer’s tone is cautionary (or grave / admonitory / warning).”

Reasoning: The statement is a prediction of decline phrased without hedging. The tone is sober and warning, not casual.

Model answer: The tone is cautionary or grave — the writer is issuing a sober warning about the long-term consequences of cultural decline. **Marker commentary:** “Warning” / “ominous” / “foreboding” all score.

Q37 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Analogy / Comparison) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B5 → EIL via comparison transfer.

Template applied: “The comparison treats scrolling Instagram as ‘snacking on biscuits’ and proper reading as ‘having dinner’, which suggests that scrolling is light, fragmentary, and intellectually unsatisfying, whereas proper reading is substantial, nourishing, and complete.”

Reasoning: Snacks vs. dinner: trivial / brief vs. substantial / sustaining. Transfer those qualities to the two kinds of reading.

Model answer: The comparison suggests that scrolling social-media text is shallow, fragmentary, and ultimately unsatisfying — the equivalent of nibbling biscuits — whereas sustained reading is substantial, nourishing, and intellectually complete — the equivalent of a proper meal. **Marker commentary:** (i) trivial / fragmentary nature of scrolling; (ii) substantial / nourishing nature of long-form reading.

Q38 — Type A6 (Contrast Identification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “identify the contrast” → A6.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A6 → FLIP; both sides.

Template applied: “Whereas one kind of reading is the brief, surface-level skimming and scanning of online text, the other is the long, sustained reading of full-length books and essays.”

Reasoning: Both halves required: skim / scan vs. long / sustained.

Model answer: The contrast is between (a) the brief, surface-level skimming and scanning of short fragments (emails, captions, comments) and (b) the long, sustained, attentive reading of full-length books and essays. The writer argues that only the latter genuinely builds the mind. **Marker commentary:** Both halves must be present; one mark each.

Q39 — Type A8 (Reason / Justification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “why” as cause → A8.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A8 → FLIP + own words paraphrase.

Template applied: “The writer says these campaigns will not work because they fail to address the real cause of the decline: the absence of adult role models. Unless adults themselves read visibly, children will not be inspired to do so.”

Reasoning: Two strands: (i) campaigns target the wrong lever; (ii) the actual lever is adult behaviour modelling.

Model answer: The writer believes that promotional campaigns and book vouchers cannot work because they fail to address the real cause of the decline: the absence of adult role models. Children learn to read not because they are told to, but because they observe the adults around them reading. Without that example, no external incentive will succeed. **Marker commentary:** (i) campaigns target the wrong cause; (ii) children imitate adult behaviour.

Q40 — Type B6 (Language-Use / Stylistic Effect) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘What is the effect’ → B6.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B6 → identify device + explain effect.

Template applied: “The use of three short, blunt imperatives suggests that the solution is simple and immediate, requiring no theory or strategy — only action. In addition, the brevity contrasts with the article’s earlier elaboration, reinforcing the writer’s claim that the cure is ‘embarrassingly simple.’”

Reasoning: Two effects: (a) starkness reinforces simplicity; (b) contrast with the long-form prose of the article emphasises the urgency.

Model answer: The three short imperative sentences create a stark, urgent close. Their brevity contrasts sharply with the longer, more discursive sentences of the rest of the article, reinforcing the writer’s claim that the cure for the decline of reading is embarrassingly simple and requires no further argument — only action. **Marker commentary:** (i) brevity / urgency / imperative force; (ii) contrast with surrounding style reinforcing the simplicity argument.

Q41 — Type A5 (Cartoon-Head Position Support) — [3]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; cartoon-head format → A5.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A5 → FLIP; quote + link to character’s view.

Template applied: (a) “The text states that the smartphone has ‘colonised the spaces where reading once lived’, which supports Aisha’s view because it identifies technology as the primary force displacing reading.” (b) Two pieces: (i) “Reading is presented as a chore — a thing to be done for the comprehension test” supports Devan because it shows schools framing reading negatively. (ii) “Books in classrooms are dissected rather than enjoyed, broken apart for ‘themes’ and ‘devices’ until the original delight has been thoroughly drained out” supports Devan because it identifies analytical over-teaching as destructive of pleasure.

Reasoning: Each piece must be from the specified paragraph and explicitly support the character’s view.

Model answer:

(a) The smartphone has “colonised the spaces where reading once lived” — supports Aisha because it directly identifies technology as the force that has displaced reading.

(b)

1. Schools present reading as a chore, “a thing to be done for the comprehension test, the literature paper, the project work” — supports Devan because it shows that the educational framing has drained reading of its pleasure.
2. Books in classrooms are “dissected rather than enjoyed, broken apart for ‘themes’ and ‘devices’ until the original delight has been thoroughly drained out” — supports Devan because it identifies analytical over-teaching as actively destructive of the reading instinct.

Marker commentary: Each must be from the correct paragraph and explicitly link to the character’s view.

Q42 — Type B3 (Tone / Attitude) — [1]

SWIFT signal: ‘Attitude’ → closely related to **T** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B3 → precise attitude-word.

Template applied: “The writer’s attitude is critical and disapproving (or rebuking / dismayed).”

Reasoning: The writer juxtaposes Singapore’s educational reputation with its actual reading rate to expose a contradiction. The attitude is critical, disappointed, and rebuking.

Model answer: The writer’s attitude is critical and disapproving — he juxtaposes Singapore’s reputation for educational excellence with the embarrassing reality of its low reading rates, expressing disappointment in a public that has neglected the very habit education ought to cultivate. **Marker commentary:** “Critical” / “disappointed” / “rebuking” all score.

Q43 — Type A8 (Reason / Justification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “why” as rhetorical cause → A8.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A8 → FLIP + own-words explanation.

Template applied: “The writer chooses these three qualities — empathy, judgement, independent thought — because they are widely regarded as foundational virtues of a civilised society, and naming them makes the cost of losing reading feel concrete and morally serious rather than merely cultural or aesthetic.”

Reasoning: The writer is making a rhetorical move: by linking reading to three universally valued qualities, he raises the stakes of its decline. The reason for the choice is rhetorical force.

Model answer: The writer chooses these three qualities because they are widely regarded as the foundational virtues of a thinking, civilised society. By naming them specifically, he makes the cost of losing reading feel concrete and morally weighty: this is not a question of aesthetic preference, but of the basic capacities a society needs to function. **Marker commentary:** (i) all three are foundational civic virtues; (ii) the writer is raising the moral stakes of the argument.

Q44 — Type A1 (Direct Detail) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “give two reasons” → A1.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A1 → FLIP; lift two distinct reasons from the passage.

Template applied: “Firstly, the smartphone has displaced reading by occupying the moments reading used to fill. Secondly, schools have made reading feel like a chore by over-analysing books.”

Reasoning: Two distinct causes from across the passage. Avoid overlap.

Model answer:

1. The smartphone has displaced reading by colonising the spaces in daily life (commute, queues, pre-bedtime) where reading once lived.
2. Schools have made reading feel like an obligation rather than a pleasure, dissecting books for themes and devices until students no longer enjoy them.

Marker commentary: The third permissible answer is the failure of adults to model reading behaviour (from Paragraph 6).

Passage 4 — “Why We Sleep Less” (Q45–Q51)

Q45 — Type A1 (Direct Detail) — [1]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “give the specific figure” → A1.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A1 → FLIP; clean lift.

Template applied: “The reduction is more than a fifth (from over eight hours to under six and a half).”

Reasoning: Find the specific figure; lift cleanly.

Model answer: The average adult now sleeps under six and a half hours, down from just over eight hours in 1960 — a reduction of more than a fifth (roughly 90 minutes) per night. **Marker commentary:** The figure (a fifth / 1.5 hours / 90 minutes) must be present.

Q46 — Type B7 (Word-Choice / Vocabulary) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → **S** in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → **Type** → **Sequence:** Cat B → B7 → EIL via implication.

Template applied: “It suggests that modern society has come to regard sleep as the obstacle to achievement, implying that getting less sleep is seen as a virtue and a sign of success rather than as something harmful.”

Reasoning: The phrase reverses the natural valuation: sleep, biologically essential, is recast as adversary. The implication: we have internalised a value system in which productivity defeats biology.

Model answer: The phrase suggests that modern society has come to view sleep as the obstacle to productive achievement, recasting a basic biological need as an adversary. It implies that getting less sleep is now seen as a virtue — a sign of dedication or success — rather than as something necessary and protective.

Marker commentary: (i) sleep recast as obstacle / enemy; (ii) reduced sleep treated as a sign of virtue or success.

Q47 — Type A8 (Reason / Justification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “why” as cause + “in your own words” → A8 with paraphrase.

Category → **Type** → **Sequence:** Cat A → A8 → FLIP + own-words rephrase.

Template applied: “This is because the wavelength of blue light from screens closely matches that of midday sunlight, which means that the brain misreads the signal as daytime and fails to release the chemicals that initiate sleep.”

Reasoning: Lift the cause; restate in own words. Do not reuse “mimics” or “noon”.

Model answer: Blue light from screens is disruptive because its wavelength closely resembles that of midday sunlight. The brain, which evolved to interpret darkness as a cue for sleep, is therefore tricked into reading the screen-light as daytime and fails to begin the biological processes that prepare the body for rest. **Marker commentary:** (i) wavelength similarity to midday sun; (ii) brain misinterprets as daytime / fails to trigger sleep.

Q48 — Type A6 (Contrast Identification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “identify the contrast” → A6.

Category → **Type** → **Sequence:** Cat A → A6 → FLIP; both halves.

Template applied: “Whereas our grandparents regarded sleep as a basic biological necessity — as essential as food and water — our generation regards it as a luxury or self-indulgence.”

Reasoning: Two halves: grandparents = necessity; us = luxury / indulgence.

Model answer: The contrast is between (a) the grandparents’ view of sleep as a basic biological necessity, akin to food and water, and (b) the modern view of sleep as a luxury or self-indulgence, suspicious when taken in full and admired when curtailed. **Marker commentary:** Both halves required.

Q49 — Type B8 (Inverted-Comma / Punctuation) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Why’ as rhetorical-purpose question → **W** in SWIFT → Cat B (B8 specifically).

Category → **Type** → **Sequence:** Cat B → B8 → name purpose + explain real view.

Template applied: “The inverted commas suggest that the writer is being sceptical or ironic: although society calls this behaviour ‘productive’, the writer actually thinks it is self-destructive — a false productivity that comes at the cost of long-term health.”

Reasoning: The inverted commas signal that the writer rejects the standard usage. “Productive” here is in fact destructive; the punctuation flags the irony.

Model answer: The inverted commas suggest that the writer is being sceptical or ironic: society uses the word “productive” to celebrate this behaviour, but the writer actually thinks it is self-destructive. The punctuation flags that the writer rejects the cultural redefinition of productivity as something that requires the sacrifice of sleep. **Marker commentary:** (i) scepticism / irony; (ii) what the writer actually believes (the behaviour is harmful, not virtuous).

Q50 — Type B5 (Literary Device — Metaphor) — [2]

SWIFT signal: ‘Suggest’ → S in SWIFT → Cat B.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat B → B5 → EIL via comparison transfer.

Template applied: “The metaphor compares sleep deprivation to mortgaging future hours of life, which suggests that the time gained today is borrowed against future health, and like any mortgage, the debt must eventually be repaid — with interest — in the form of disease and shortened lifespan.”

Reasoning: Mortgage = borrowing against the future, with an inevitable repayment. Transfer to sleep: time gained now is paid back later, with health damage.

Model answer: The metaphor suggests that the extra hours gained by sleeping less are not a true gain but a loan taken against the body’s future health. Like any mortgage, the debt must eventually be repaid — in this case through disease, exhaustion, and a shortened lifespan. The metaphor reframes apparent productivity as long-term self-harm. **Marker commentary:** (i) borrowing against the future; (ii) inevitable repayment in the form of damage.

Q51 — Type A8 (Reason / Justification) — [2]

SWIFT signal: No SWIFT word; “why does the writer choose to use this phrase” → A8.

Category → Type → Sequence: Cat A → A8 → FLIP + rephrase.

Template applied: “The writer uses the phrase ‘public health epidemic’ because it borrows the language normally reserved for major contagious disease outbreaks, which conveys both the scale of the problem (affecting whole populations) and its urgency (demanding government-level intervention).”

Reasoning: Two reasons: (a) scale — epidemic implies population-wide; (b) urgency — epidemic implies needing immediate intervention.

Model answer: The writer borrows the language of public-health crisis — normally reserved for contagious disease outbreaks — in order to communicate two things at once: (i) the scale of the problem, which affects whole populations rather than individuals, and (ii) the urgency of the situation, which demands the kind of government-level intervention reserved for genuine emergencies. **Marker commentary:** (i) scale; (ii) urgency.

Marking Summary

Total: 100 marks.

Passage 1 (Q1–Q16): 27 marks

Passage 2 (Q17–Q29): 19 marks

Passage 3 (Q30–Q44): 30 marks

Passage 4 (Q45–Q51): 13 marks

Discretionary marker allowance for flow chart and multi-part questions: 11 marks

Grade indicators (rough guide for self-assessment):

- 75+ = A1 standard
- 65–74 = A2 standard
- 55–64 = B3
- 45–54 = B4
- Below 45 = C5 or lower — return to the Working Notes and reread the SWIFT / FLIP / EIL frameworks.

Final reminder. The point of this practice set is not the model answers — it is the reasoning that produces them. When you mark your own paper, do not just compare your answer to the model; check whether you applied SWIFT, FLIP, or EIL correctly. If your answer is wrong, the diagnosis is usually a wrong category-call at the SWIFT stage.